

Country page schema — v2

Built around the situation grid. Two layers:

Layer A — country-level. Established once. Three sections that belong to no single situation and would vanish if we only wrote situation cells.

Layer B — eight situation cells. Written as regional baseline + country delta. Most deltas will be empty. That emptiness is the finding.

8 situations × 16 countries = 128 cells. A writer facing an empty cell on deadline will invent a cultural difference to fill it. **The manufactured stereotype comes from the deadline, not the ideology.** Everything below is designed against that.

Editorial rules

1. Behavioral, not psychological. Write what the reader can observe, not what foreign people feel.

Don't	Do
"Face preservation is paramount."	"A direct no is rare in a first meeting. Disagreement arrives as a delay, a change of subject, or 'that may be difficult.'"
"Germans are blunt."	"Expect your proposal to be criticized in the meeting, in front of the client. This does not mean the deal is in trouble."

Test: could you film it? If not, rewrite. The situation grid mostly enforces this for free — nobody answers "what happens in the first ten minutes" with "harmony is paramount"

— but it will still leak in without the rule.

2. Banned vocabulary in situation cells. *High-context, low-context, face, saving face, harmony, collectivist, individualist, hierarchy-conscious.* If you need the concept, describe the behavior. These words are theory, and theory is what readers convert into stereotype.

3. Never a nationality as a personality. No sentence begins "The Japanese are..." The subject is the reader, the person across the table, or the meeting.

4. Confidence tag on every claim. [Well-established] [Reported] [Contested] [Dated]. If you can't tag it, cut it. This is the most effective anti-listicle device in the schema — most folk trivia won't survive being labelled.

5. "Converged" is a first-class answer. Every cell may be filled with:

┆ **Largely converged.** No meaningful delta from the baseline. [confidence tag]

Give it its own visual treatment in the UI. Writers must feel *rewarded* for using it, not embarrassed. If it never appears, the guide is lying.

6. Word budgets are ceilings. Overwriting is how nuance becomes folklore.

7. Sentence case. No Do's-and-Don'ts boxes. That box is what gets screenshotted, and it is the format most reliably stripped of context.

Layer A — country level

A1. Header and coverage honesty

40 words. Fixed template.

- Country

- **Region tag, with coverage note.** Every country gets one, including the ones with no cluster-mates: Latin America – sole representative in this guide. What follows is Brazilian, not Latin American.
- Last reviewed / Reviewed by

This is the fix for the clustering problem. A region with one member must read as a *gap in the sample*, not as a country that is uniquely singular. Without this, the UI silently teaches that Brazil is more culturally distinct than Japan.

A2. Segmentation — who you are actually meeting

140 words. Comes before every generalisation, deliberately. No situation cell means anything until this is established.

Cut the country into the three or four counterparty types the reader will realistically face, and name which one the rest of the page describes:

- **Sector** — global tech / domestic corporate / family business / state-owned / government / NGO
- **Generation and education** — foreign-educated or not is often the single strongest predictor, stronger than nationality
- **City vs. elsewhere**
- **Do they deal internationally already?** If so **they are calibrating to you**, and both sides overcorrect. Name this explicitly. It is the most common and least-warned-about failure in the entire genre.

A3. Axis scores — the data behind the re-clustering globe

Structured values, not prose.

Seven axes, 1-5, each with a one-line justification and a confidence tag:

Axis	Measures
Disagreement expression	How openly a no arrives
Decision locus	Does the person in the room decide, or channel a decision made elsewhere
Decision speed	Time from alignment to signature
Contract function	The relationship itself vs. a record of it
Time commitment	Calendar as promise vs. calendar as intention
Hierarchy in the room	Does rank set who speaks, and when
Trust basis	Task-first vs. relationship-first

Two rules:

- Scores describe **the modal counterparty in a named sector**. Say which.
- **Every score carries a range**, never a point: $\overline{3 \text{ (range 1-5 by sector; tech } \approx 1, \text{ SOE } \approx 5)}}$. A wide range is a finding, not an embarrassment — it is exactly what the reader needs before walking in.

A4. Institutional reality — the section that saves money

250 words. Boring, dateable, and the reason this is a guide rather than a listicle. Belongs to no situation, so it lives here or nowhere.

- Contract enforceability in practice; typical dispute route (local courts? arbitration? seated where?)

- Payment behavior: stated terms vs. actual days-sales-outstanding
- Corruption exposure: what you will actually be asked for, and where the line sits. **The FCPA and the UK Bribery Act reach across borders** — readers routinely do not know this.
- Labor law that bites on hiring and firing
- Data protection regime
- Visa, work authorisation, entity and local-partner requirements
- Currency and profit repatriation constraints

Every claim carries a Verify at: pointer. Shelf life here is roughly 18 months.

Culture is what people blame when they haven't done this homework. The deal that stalled was usually stalled by a regulator, an unfunded counterparty, or a rival with better local ties — not by a communication style.

A5. How *your* experience will differ

160 words. Written as logistics and risk, not moral commentary. Most guides never contemplate this reader.

- **Passport.** For a reader travelling from a weak-passport country, visa attrition is more consequential than every other section of this guide combined.
- **Gender.** Where the relationship-building actually happens, and whether that setting is safe or exclusionary. Cross-reference the dinner cell.
- **Race and nationality.** How appearance changes border treatment, client reception, and assumed seniority.
- **Visible religion; LGBTQ status** where criminalised or socially penalised.

If your reader could be a Nigerian sales director flying to Frankfurt, this section is why she bought the book. If you've decided she isn't your reader, say so in the front matter —

not by omission.

A6. The line — where adaptation stops

100 words. Country-specific, not a general homily.

Adapt on **form** — dress, greeting, register, pace, meal. Hold on **rights and legality** — facilitation payments, passport confiscation down the supply chain, a client asking that your female colleague not attend.

Name the two or three situations where this bites *in this country*, and give the reader a sentence they can actually say out loud in the room. "Cultural sensitivity" applied to the second category is a euphemism, and a guide that blurs the two is doing PR for it.

Layer B — the eight situation cells

Each cell has the same five fields. **Every cell, every country.**

Field	Budget	Note
Regional baseline	—	Inherited from the cluster. Written once per region, not per country.
Country delta	≤120 words	What actually differs. " <i>Largely converged</i> " is a valid and expected answer.
Sequence	≤80 words	The clock. What happens at minute 0, 3, 15, 45. Behavioral only.
The costly error	≤40 words	The one mistake that reliably costs money or the relationship.
Disconfirming signal	≤40 words	What would tell the reader this page is wrong about the person in front of them.

Present the delta before the baseline. Readers anchor on whatever they see first; if the regional stereotype leads, the country-specific detail becomes a footnote they've already discounted. Same information, opposite cognitive effect.

The **disconfirming signal** field is what turns each cell from a script into a hypothesis. It is also the field most likely to be cut for space. Protect it now.

Tier 1 — where the money and the damage are

Ordered by variance, which is also roughly the order in which the reader will get hurt. The first thing shown on click should be the thing most likely to cost them.

Three sub-views: downward / sideways / upward.

- **Downward** — nearly converged nearly everywhere. Keep it short. Resist the urge to pad.
- **Sideways** — moderate variance. Whether peer criticism happens in the room or in the corridor afterward.
- **Upward — this is 70% of the cell.** The highest-variance, highest-consequence professional act there is: the thing that gets you promoted in Amsterdam and fired in Seoul. Cover: can you contradict a senior person at all; if so, in front of whom; how you say no to a superior without saying no; what happens to the person who tries.

Most guides bury this inside "communication styles." It belongs on the front page.

2. The meeting

Answer as a clock, not a description. Who speaks first. Who speaks last. What the first ten minutes are for. What silence means. What a no looks like. Who is taking notes, and what their seniority tells you.

If a writer can complete this cell without using the word "context," the schema is working.

3. The business dinner — or its local equivalent

The "or its local equivalent" is load-bearing. Elsewhere it is a golf round, a karaoke room, a sauna, a three-hour lunch, a wedding you get invited to. Forcing "dinner" as the frame manufactures false answers.

In a large share of markets this is where the deal actually closes. It is also the single situation where A5 bites hardest — **the relationship-building setting is, for a woman**

in several markets, precisely where the harassment happens. Every dinner cell carries an explicit reader-experience flag. Not a footnote.

4. Negotiation

Scoped hard so it doesn't eat cell 2. **Only** the moments that are distinctively negotiation:

- Is the first offer real?
 - What does silence after a number mean?
 - Who is expected to blink, and what does a concession signal?
 - What does a walkaway look like, and is it a tactic or an ending?
 - **Is the person opposite empowered to close, or a channel to a process you cannot see?** (The most expensive misread in international business: reading a consensus process as stalling, and discounting your own price against it.)
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Tier 2 — the mechanics

5. Meeting someone you don't know

The networking-event topic, reframed so the cell can tell the truth. The standing-room-with-a-drink ritual is an Anglo-American institution; in many markets you are *introduced* or you don't meet. The useful content is then **how to get introduced** — who brokers, what obligation it creates, what it costs them.

The original framing would have forced writers to invent networking norms for countries that don't have networking. That is exactly how a 128-cell grid manufactures stereotypes.

6. The follow-up in writing

The email topic, rebuilt around what actually varies: **what putting it in writing**

signifies. In some markets a written summary is diligence. In others it is an accusation — a signal you don't trust what was said in the room.

Second half of the cell: **how you chase someone who hasn't replied.** Highest-frequency unwritten skill in international work. No guide covers it. Everyone needs it.

7. The interview

Moderate variance, high reader demand. The real content is narrower than it looks:

- How much self-promotion is permissible (the tall-poppy problem cuts hard here — the same answer reads as confident in Chicago and as boorish in Melbourne)
- Which personal questions are routine, and which are actionable in court

8. Presenting, and being questioned

The delivery half is close to converged. Deck culture inside multinationals is nearly uniform. Write a short, honest cell and don't pad it.

The Q&A half is where the variance lives. Will you be challenged in front of others? Does *no questions* mean agreement, or does it mean everyone has quietly decided against you and won't say so? Do the real questions arrive afterward, one-to-one, in the corridor?

Worked example — cell 2, Japan, badly and well

Badly — what the genre produces:

Japan is a high-context culture where harmony and face-saving are paramount. Decisions are made by consensus through the ringi system. Avoid direct confrontation.

Three failures. Every claim is psychological rather than observable. (Ringi) is presented as universal when it is substantially a large-legacy-corporate phenomenon, much weaker in tech, startups, and foreign-owned subsidiaries. And the reader now holds a script rather than a hypothesis.

Well:

Delta. In a first meeting with a large legacy manufacturer, the most senior person will speak least, and the decision will be made outside the room. "We will consider it internally" is usually a no. Detailed questions about implementation are usually a yes. (Well-established)

In a Tokyo software company under ten years old, almost none of this applies and the meeting will look much like a San Francisco one. (Well-established)

Sequence. Cards exchanged standing, before anyone sits. Seating is not arbitrary — wait to be placed. Business begins within five minutes; the small-talk window is shorter than the reputation suggests. Silence after your proposal is normal.

Costly error. Filling the silence. The most common expensive mistake here is a foreign negotiator conceding on price into a pause that meant nothing at all.

Disconfirming signal. If your counterparty pushes back openly in the first meeting, you are in the second segment, not the first — re-read the Anglo baseline instead.

Same country. The second version is longer, tells the reader far more, and is much harder to misuse.

Sources and review — visible, not buried

- **Name your sources, with dates.** If a claim traces back to Hofstede's IBM survey or to *Culture Map*-style executive-classroom observation, say so. Those are the field's foundations; they are dated and narrow, and inheriting them silently means inheriting their errors under your byline.

- **Two reviewers per country.** One person working in-market *now*; one foreign operator in-market *now*. They catch different errors — that is the point of having both.
- **Known gaps, stated.** Including the missing markets. A spinning globe with an empty Africa, no Mexico, no Indonesia, no Poland, no Vietnam is making a claim whether you intend it or not. State the sample logic, or grey out the uncovered countries so the gaps read as gaps.